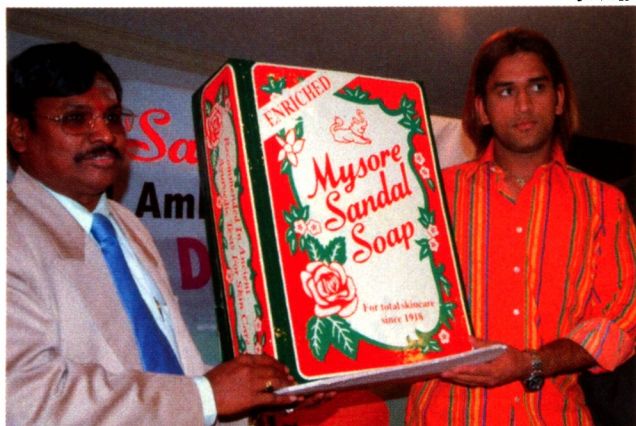


B K RAMESH



Bowled and Caught

BANGALORE One-day cricket captain Mahendra Singh Dhoni may well be celebrating India's first ODI win over Sri Lanka in Sri Lanka, but the grapevine has it that he will be soon starring in a soap opera. The cricket icon has found himself in a legal wrangle over an endorsement deal with Karnataka Soaps and

Detergents Ltd (KSDL), a state government undertaking which manufactures Mysore Sandal Soaps.

The soap company alleges that Dhoni has failed to provide the Rs 40-lakh compensation after he breached a two-year contract he signed with it in January 2006. The KSDL moved the

SILLY POINT: Dhoni

Karnataka High Court, which has now asked the swashbuckling captain to either send a representative or appear in person on September 11.

Two years ago, KSDL had roped in Dhoni—then not as well-known as he is now—to sell its soaps, paying his endorsement company, Sporting and Outdoor Solutions, about Rs 64 lakh, after capping the deal at about Rs 84 lakh. The rest was to be paid later. However, the company says that Dhoni did not spare even 10 days for the promotional work due to which his contract was terminated in December 2007, a month before it was to officially expire. Now, this is a googly that Dhoni may find difficult to tackle.

by Stephen David

Inspired Travelling

BHOPAL Drawing inspiration from leaders like L.K. Advani, Uma Bharati and Narendra Modi, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan too has embarked upon the "Jan Ashirvaad Yatra" as a time-tested formula for success to recapture Madhya Pradesh. Chauhan aims to cover 3,000 km by road in his specially-designed rath. As the yatra finishes a good one month before the state goes to polls, it would allow the party's poll managers to fine-tune their strategy while there is still some time left. The



PAWAN BHAWAR

THE RIGHT TREK: Chauhan

yatra will culminate on October 2.

When the BJP's prime ministerial candidate Advani flagged off the Yatra from Ujjain, Chauhan knew what he was getting into. He understands that he has the huge responsibility of delivering the state to his

party not in the upcoming Assembly polls but in the 2009 general elections too. Flanked by Venkaiah Naidu, BJP's election campaign in-charge and Ananth Kumar, who is heading Madhya Pradesh, Advani dwelt at length on several national issues, which makes it clear that the party is looking at the future. by Ambresh Mishra

Tusker Trouble

BANGALORE The big occasion for pomp and splendour down south, the Mysore Dasara Procession this year is in for a mammoth problem—the leader of the elephants, Balarama, who carries the 750-kg howdah of the Goddess Chamundeshwari on his back. While the organisers insist that the 50-year-old Balarama perform his rightful duties, the Forest Department has intervened saying that the aged tusker must not carry the howdah in the procession that will last for over two hours.

Balarama's predeces-



AP PHOTO

DILEMMA: The procession

sor Drona stopped being part of the procession nearly a decade ago, when he was electrocuted after stepping on a live wire. The officials have found a common voice in Srikantadatta Wodeyar of the Mysore royal family, who has also expressed his reservations about the aged pachyderm lifting the load. With the Jambu Savari (elephant procession) being the main attraction at the Dasara, the organisers, the Government and the forest officials are a worried bunch because there is not enough time to train another elephant in this short period—to carry the weight as well as deal with the surging crowds.

by Nirmala Ravindran